

HONEY BADGER

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I AM certain who's going to hate their caricature before I've even uncapped the marker. Typically, the same: housewives with electrolyzed calves who can't quit touching their faces while talking, incel-types with Mountain Dew breath who undress me with their eyes, and the high school couples with the gravitas of Mexican jumping beans, whose relationships are on the brink of collapse.

Those customers, I can manage. The ones I hate are the ones who say: Make me look good, because I can't say, Sorry, but I can't make you look good because that is a subjective thing and I can only make you look the way you look, and if you are uncomfortable with this, well, I'm sorry, may I direct you to Randy, a portrait artist, about five minutes down that way? But they generally don't understand that a caricaturist and a portrait artist are not the same thing, so then after agreeing that it's all super confusing, I'd direct them to his booth – wedged between the giant spinning teacups and jumbo hot dog stand – and explain how he'll kindly ignore the countless warts that litter their scalp and mindfully proportion their other features with respect to their ginormous Roman nose, and sorry, but that's not an insult,

because a good Roman nose actually makes me vaguely horny. But it happens to be conventional material for a caricaturist, so I will have to utilize it. But Randy won't.

Today, I'm sketching a fifteen-year-old girl. I'm guessing fifteen, but teenagers these days are characteristically less teenage-like and look six hundred years old and are always in this exhaustive rebellion against the anachronistic morality of their parents. Or, they look as if CoComelon, but specifically the main baby from the show, grew up and started working in influencer marketing.

"Hi," the girl says, examining the plastic chair before sitting down. "How often do you clean this?"

"Hi," I say. She has bright, box-dyed green hair, and it reminds me of the Green Party, or Serrano peppers. "Not often."

"Well, you're having me sit on butt sweat and gooch grease and I'm supposed to pay you thirty dollars and fifty cents—" she squints at the price list clipped on the back of the easel, "—oh, and you charge ten dollars to include pet portraits, so *forty* dollars and fifty cents."

I do not know what a gooch is. "Take my chair," I say. I want to add that it's ten dollars per pet, in case she has several, another common misconception among customers. "How often do you wipe your chair?" she asks.

"Less than the other one."

"Well, see, that's really disgusting," she says, and rummages through her tote bag for something. "Can I sit on the floor?"

"The angle will be weird."

I think about the floor being infinitely dirtier than the chair – sun-baked concrete layered with years' worth of wet bread rolls and sticky grape soda and ketchup packets and yeast infection and the watery, gloopy parts of sunscreen.

She pulls a disinfectant wipe from her tote, wipes her

chair, then walks over and wipes mine. She asks if the pet portrait fee is for pets collectively or if it's for each pet. I say it's for pets in the individual sense, but I can give her a discount if she just sits down.

"How many pets do you have?" I ask. I clip a fresh sheet of Bristol paper to the board, and it immediately buckles at the corners from the humidity.

"Two," she chirps, using the pad of her index finger to apply a thin layer of lip balm. She flings her tote on the ground, right onto a fossilized glob of Juicy Fruit. "A Ball Python, Beezo. And a boyfriend."

"Very funny," I say plainly. "Any reference photos?"

She bends down with a grunt to retrieve an iPhone from her tote, which couldn't have been more dilapidated if it were pulled out of meth van wreckage. I squint, trying to make out the outlines on her cracked screen.

"Where's the boyfriend?" I ask, toying with a marker.

She ignores the question and points to the marker, asking if I ever unintentionally get "high" from the smell, and if I did, would she be able to give it a sniff? I say no and ask to see a reference photo of Beezo and the boyfriend. "Or else," I say, "I'll draw a doting portrait of you and Jesus Christ."

She begins sniffing, which I think is the start of a pre-teen prank, but then her shoulders start shaking and her eyes get all blurry and wet.

"Sorry," I say. "It was a bad joke."

But she doesn't care about my apology, which was disingenuous anyway, so I begin sketching the outline and remind myself to stop saying more than *bello* or the occasional *what's good* to pre-teens.

Her head is cocked slightly to the side so I see it from a three-quarter view rather than a straight-ahead perspective, generally something that insecure people with asymmetrical facial profiles do to avoid seeing themselves in an unmirrored

depiction. I'm certain of it, having worked with the pudding-faced, dying-for-plastic-surgery types.

I stopped wondering if the moral responsibility of managing strangers' self-esteem issues is my kismet or if the feeling of indifference about it means that I'm a bad person, or worse, a bad artist. When people ask me about the morality of the business, I say that it's totally not personal. I'm just supposed to reference a deeply flawed and highly personal taxonomy of human faces, beginning with geometric blocking, and focused on the obvious: abnormal head shapes, general asymmetries, and defining features such as triangle noses, teeth gaps, hairline placement, and chins that are sharp or butt-like or nonexistent, to name some.

The girl's chin is unremarkable.

I ask her to please move her head so I can see it straight-on, and she obeys. I ask if she's religious, because maybe that's why she burst into tears since it was right after I mentioned Jesus, and she gestures dramatically to her green hair and says, "Are you blind? And if I were religious, why would that make me *cry*?"

"Religious people seem to always be crying about those kinds of things," I say, which is not a lie, like crying when they catch sight of Jesus Christ swinging from a car freshener or when Facebook chainmail graphics say "HE IS COMING!!!!!!" in fat, bold letters along with a proverb and a mushy-looking sunset in the background.

"Maybe you're thinking about people too much," she says.

"It's my job." I cock an eyebrow to myself, and she catches it, bulling her beak forward like a flouncy male bird as if she's about to pluck out my feathers and says, "What? Has nobody *clocked* you before?"

I tell her I don't know what that means – and is that analogous, or a figure of speech, or slang?

“You’re using words performatively,” she informs me. “And, can I ask you something?”

“No.”

I switch to a warm gray Tombrow and begin sketching her eyes, which are downturned and rimmed with blue eyeliner and still kind of sad-looking, so I plump them up like fried Oreos and bloat them with tears.

“Why are you so old, and like, doing this?”

I don’t look up from the easel, but I think about this for a moment. I’m not sure which question sours, within me, more profoundly, being so old, or being such a sell-out?

“It just sort of happens. Getting older,” I say. I begin sketching her nose. “And I’ve always been good at drawing, I guess.”

“Yeah, yeah.” She rolls her eyes. “But why you, specifically? You look like you should be working at Walmart.”

I tell her I would not look good in those blue vests, and she asks why I can’t take insults like a normal person. I ask if working at Walmart is supposed to be insulting, and she doesn’t answer. Instead, she tries another – I look like the type of person who, when eating chicken wings, really eats the whole thing good and definitely licks the bones clean.

“Should I be eating them differently?” I ask, thinking about how I might eat a chicken wing, suddenly forgetting.

“I don’t know,” she scoffs. “I’m a vegetarian.”

I fill in her narrow, base-width nose, which has the sharpness of a pewter spoon handle, the kind I instantly peg as Anglo-Saxon. That kind of profile rarely inspires compliments. She tries another insult – I look like I was bottle-fed as a baby, because apparently, babies who are bottle-fed turn out very different from babies who are breastfed, and I ask her to elaborate, because I’m genuinely curious, but she doesn’t.

She stands up to peek at the easel. "I look fat and devastated."

I point to her seat. "I'm not done."

She pulls a hot pink vape from her bra. It has a mini touchscreen, and when she inhales, it lights up with a pixelated Borat, his middle finger slowly darting up and down, then back down and up again. She definitely won't know who he is, so I don't bother asking her why she has a Borat vape.

"Can you not breathe that in my face?" I wave through the cloud of green apple smoke. "You're such a baby!" She laughs and extends the vape to me. A peace offering. I decline and say that though I don't really care if she lives or dies, she's breathing in LED lights and Cadmium and probably something manufactured during the Industrial Revolution. She's quiet. I flip the board toward her, watching for her initial reaction. In the brief moment of every reveal, there's either a beat of silence followed by an *Ahhhh* or an *Obhhh* (indicator: bad, offended), or instant hysterics (indicator: good, maybe I'll get tipped). She leans in, squinting like she's unsure.

"You made me look like...I'm cool," she says, finally.

"You are cool."

"Thanks." She drops a twenty-dollar bill into the tip jar. "I'm June."

"Marnie," I say. "Come back soon."

I never say things like that because I know how pointless it is. Nobody comes back, not to this booth, at least, and I don't want them to anyway, but the twenty-dollar tip is flickering in the jar, and that's how much I make in two hours. It's a jumbo salted pretzel with plastic melty cheese and a large blue raspberry slushie at the mall.

"You're only saying that because I tipped you," she says, matter-of-factly. I shrug. The sun is refracting off her box-dyed green hair. She reminds me of myself, if I were way younger and smarter and cooler, but I don't tell her that.

June takes another puff, and Borat flips me off again on the little vape screen. She leaves me in one more pall of green apple smoke.

It's Thursday afternoon, just four days later, when June visits my booth again. It's also my twenty-sixth birthday. I'm finishing up a caricature for a dead-eyed, middle-aged conspiracy theorist with chewed-up nails and sandy-toned khakis that expose too much inner thigh. He's giving me a matador's stare as I decorate his face with twenty-six zits, a quiet homage to my birthday, something that will deeply offend him in a few minutes.

I see June, out of the corner of my eye, slowly walking up to my booth. She sits on an empty chair by the cash register, makes eye contact with me, and makes a face at the man sitting across from me.

He drones on and on about public subsidies and Oswald Spengler (which I assume is Oswald the Lucky Rabbit's government name), and how the fake volcanoes at the Dells are actually the mouths of hell where liberals go to corrupt God-fearin' folk and initiate them into Satanist cults. I say that sounds interesting.

June taps her feet impatiently.

I spin the caricature around. He remains still before standing up and a greasy something not good is slicked on the plastic chair. He swipes his card and leaves the portrait behind.

"Just throw the whole thing away," June mouths, walking up to me. Her face crinkles in disgust as she examines the chair. "Gooch grease, if you remember me saying. That'd be this."

I tell her to take my chair, and that I'll draw her standing

up because I have a herniated disc and my back hurts if I sit for too long.

“Wow, you really *are* old.”

I place a fresh sheet of paper on the easel and squint at her. “Not satisfied with the last one?” I ask. “Because you kind of look the same as four days ago.”

“I lost it.” She bends down and pulls a tube of disinfectant wipes from her tote, rolling it by my feet. “For your business.”

I tell her she doesn’t have to do that, but thank her anyway, and ask if she’d like some kind of impressionistic take for her caricature today or if she wants me to make something similar to the last one. She asks if I can make her look “soft,” and maybe it’s because I have no creative license or artistic integrity anymore, but I’m used to making people look Hard, not Soft (unless I’m leaning on fatness, which is generally a lazy, lowbrow trick), so I ask her to elaborate on what soft looks like, for her.

She begins trailing off about the boyfriend. He’s an “E-boy,” she claims, and she’s been feeling insecure about it lately. I say that I don’t know what an E-boy is, like, does it stand for Electronic Boy? Have they released robot boyfriends already, and why didn’t I hear about this?

She admits she doesn’t know what “E-boy” stands for, but it’s a “whole thing,” because they supposedly only go for “Soft girls,” and she’s not really a “Soft girl” but a “Normal girl,” and she’s terrified of being normal.

“It’s Wisconsin,” I laugh. “Everybody is normal.”

“But you’re not,” she says, and it seems like a compliment, but I’m not entirely sure.

She explains why her hair is green, how she had an identity crisis four days ago, thanks to her boyfriend, Spence, who followed a guild of “E-girls” on Instagram, and that’s another demographic she has to compete with now.

“But,” she dissents, “I’ve been tracking his following

recently, and the data shows that he's into 'Soft girls' again, and 'Soft girls' always win, at the end of the day, which is good for me, but now I have to dye my hair again."

"So, what, you want me to make you look both 'Soft' and 'E?'" I ask.

"That doesn't even make sense."

I tell her every word that's come out of her mouth in the last ten minutes has been completely made up, and we fall into a moody silence. I'm not sure why, but I keep offending her.

She tells me why she came to get her portrait drawn in the first place. She needed a new profile picture that's cool in a detached way – how she'd kept all her profile pictures the same for two years, so it would mean *something* when she finally changed it, how she used to change them all the time, and how lame is that, looking so unsure of herself like that, so publicly. "Not that it mattered anyway," she says, "I looked too ugly so I couldn't update it even if I wanted to, I probably need to wait another year, which is fine, because it gives me more time to get *softer*."

"I thought you lost it?"

She shrugs. I ask if she meant to see Randy, the portrait artist, and she says, "Yeah, but I like this booth better." She's quiet when she adds, "You remind me of my sister. A little."

"What's her name?" I ask.

"Uh, anyway. Yeah," she mumbles, correcting herself reflexively as if I'd misunderstood her. "So I wasn't born with green hair and my natural color is strawberry blonde, sort of like yours, but not as mousy, and I actually dyed it on Sunday, right before coming to the park."

"Ah, that's why it was so lustrous then," I say. "Like leafy greens in season."

"It's because of all the shit those companies put inside the special conditioners." Her phone makes two little beeps, and she turns it face down in her lap. "Silica." "There's probably

silica in your vape juice, too,” I say. I don’t mean to bring up the vaping again, but the outline of it is much too distracting in her front pocket, and for some reason, it’s really bothering me that she’s killing herself so slowly and casually like that.

She pulls it out. It’s different from yesterday’s, an ugly, highlighter-yellow color with smoke that smells like overripe bananas. No Borat.

While I sketch a new outline, I study her face shape, which is round, but unlike all other round shapes, there’s less equality concerning the width and length of her face, almost defying the rules of the six primary face shapes: round, oval, heart, square, rectangle, and diamond. Mine is diamond, characteristically so with my narrow forehead and chin, and hers is something beyond what I know or what’s available in my caricature taxonomy.

“You have a unique face shape,” I tell her.

She frowns. “That’s code for ugly.”

“If I meant ugly, I would’ve said interesting,” I say. “Does your sister have a similar shape?”

“How old are you?” she asks. “I know you’re not supposed to ‘ask a lady her age’ and all, but you’re like, more of a lunch-lady type of *lady*,” she informs me.

“You’ll never know.” I fling a disinfectant wipe at her. June is one fart away from twenty-six, which just feels too old and silly to explain now. “Look.”

“Hm.” She examines the caricature. “I look like her. It’s the smile. We have that same gummy smile.”

I don’t ask who she’s referencing, out of respect and in an attempt to avoid another awkward bout of silence, but after a pause – I’m shading in her cheeks and behind us, a group of rowdy kids passes by holding funnel cakes – June reveals that her older sister died two years ago. She keeps her eyes on the ground when she says there are moments, not a lot, but some, *enough*, when we are chatting or tiffing, that she’s reminded of

her. I am quiet. I always wondered what it'd be like to have a sister. I have two older brothers I don't talk to.

"I'm sorry," I say, which is what I'm only capable of managing. She waves it off but is thinking about it more now.

"My mom used to say we were like honey badgers, because they're small and fearless, but, like, apparently also very aggressive? I don't know. I think she saw it in a nature documentary."

"I didn't know that about them," I say. At her age, I was attaching claw clips to my thigh fat and wondering which boy bands would adopt me and probably didn't know what a documentary was. We go quiet for a few minutes, listening to the lemonade machines nearby, cycling their sugary-watery gloopiness. The kids and their funnel cakes have disappeared. "But you have friends to lean on, right?"

She explains how it's hard for her to make friends and she feels embarrassed about it sometimes, but it's okay because *I* don't seem like I have very many friends, and it looks like *I'm* doing okay, plus she's going to move out of the state soon, probably to California or Las Vegas or Portland, where she'll make friends in college, or sell upcycled motorcycle jackets by the beach.

"These are good thoughts to be having," I say. "Much better than worrying about being an 'E-girl,' or a 'Soft' one, or whatever the fuck...whatever you think the boyfriend wants you to be." She stirs uncomfortably. "Your boyfriend, I mean. He seems stupid."

"Just because I said all that doesn't mean that you really are my sister, or that you're required to give me big sister advice now."

"Yes, I know that," I say. "I'm telling you because it's a fact and I know that you know it, but sometimes it's good to hear it. Plus, I'm twenty-six years old today, and that's pretty old, according to you, and my birthday wish is to be a know-it-all."

“Nice job making me feel like shit,” she says. She points to the disinfectant wipes with her shoe. “Will you accept those as a gift, though, really? It’s okay if not, because it doesn’t really count as a real gift, technically, since my mom bought it with her money.”

“I accept,” I say. “Thanks.”

It’s the only gift I received that day.

June comes back three days later. Then again, a few days after that. It becomes a semi-regular thing – she’s at my booth at least twice a week. Once school starts, she comes on weekends, lingering after I finish her caricature, slipping away while I work on someone else’s, buying us pulled pork sundaes – she’s not a vegetarian after all – and large diet sodas, or paper wands of cotton candy. Sometimes we eat on my lunch break and people-watch, and I give her the big sisterly advice I’m not accredited to be giving, which she doesn’t admit is the reason she keeps coming back.

She talks about her boyfriend, Spence, and her best friend, Laura, who moved away to Minnesota last summer and won’t answer her calls. She sneaks Beezo to the park and swaps the prize tags on the claw machine so the giant stuffed pandas are labeled “small prizes.” She asks me about my life, why I’m stuck here with everyone else, why I can’t just run away to Nevada and do caricatures there, because apparently, there’s a huge market for it in Las Vegas, which she’s done research on through TikTok.

“Maybe one day,” I tell her.

“You don’t believe in yourself,” she says. “But I do. I do, Marnie, I believe in your art.” I start to wonder where the money comes from. I don’t want to charge her, but it’s against

policy to give discounts for family or friends, though she never asks for one anyway. Just swipes the card.

“Is that your dad’s credit card?” I ask June, one of the days.

She’s in a weird mood and just dyed her hair lavender, the ends stringy and dry and already in need of a touch-up. She’s finally heard back from Laura, who apologized over email for being “so busy” and sent June a photo album of her with all her new friends from school.

“Ha! My Dad’s a bum with a drinking problem,” June says. “Mom’s the provider, which I think now makes you sexist and maybe even ageist for assuming I can’t make my own money?”

“Mhm,” I grunt. “Got me.”

I don’t know her well enough yet to sense that she may be lying.

By the following summer, the caricature booth had moved ten feet to the left to accommodate a large, high-tech trash bin that made robotic beeping noises, and June was sixteen-and-a-half, transferred to a new high school, and had outgrown the green hair.

“It’s over,” she says, letting her tote bag slip off her shoulder, which hits the hot concrete with a thud. “Are you happy?”

She’s sporting a new look, thick streaks of bleached hair, unevenly and randomly strewn about her head. I’m hoping she’s referring to her dud of a boyfriend, Spence, but I play it cool. “What, using purple shampoo?” I ask. “We need to tone whatever’s happening on your head.”

She laughs, bent over her tote, and pulls out a can of root beer for us to share. I’m sitting across from her, still next to my easel, still

doing this stupid job. Only now, I'm sixteen pounds heavier with plum-colored stretchmarks on my belly and have callouses in the webby part between my fingers from an unusually busy season. I've drawn so many faces I'm forgetting the shape of my own.

"No, seriously," she says, her pupils fat and moon-like. "I did it. I broke up with him. Like you suggested."

I relax in my seat a little and clip a fresh sheet of paper to the easel while she explains how – in the Dairy Queen parking lot, minutes before his graveyard shift. She confronted him with "receipts" of his Snapchats with a co-worker, then told him to "eat a bunghole and die." I forget Snapchat exists until someone uses it as a verb, like, *Yeah, we were snapping.*

"Did I waste my time?" she asks. We're passing the root beer back and forth. I notice a small, red-ish mark on her forearm, probably from her hair straightener.

"You can't waste time if you spend it learning something," I say.

"But I didn't learn anything," she says. "Except that I'm really dumb. Really, really dumb, and just always willing to let myself go."

It feels impossible to give her anything real to chew on. I look at her and think about all the versions of myself I've tried on and shrugged off. I don't want to just say, *You'll figure it out!*

"You'll figure it out," I say, and immediately hate myself for it. "And you'll probably dye your hair badly eight more times along the way."

"It'll be twenty more times at least." She tries to laugh after saying it.

I ask if she's still vaping, and if she is, that's the next thing we're going to knock off the list, and there were only those two things – the toxic boyfriend and the vaping, and now that the first thing is gone, the second should be easier.

“Fuck no,” she says. She pulls out a vape with a green apple emoji on it and waves it around like I’m a joke.

I think about how I’m failing at the older sister act. This is usually when the gig is up, when the older one is failing hopelessly at life and can’t be a good example, let alone a bad one, because there are just no examples of anything to be shown or taught or learned from, because the older one is just a laughable, dreary pixel in the video game. And soon enough, the younger one – her, the baby sister – figures it out and begins avoiding the older one, me, afraid she’ll end up the same.

“So.” She pulls her legs up to the chair, folding herself into a knot. “How about that caricature?”

“Already started,” I say. “You’re going through a breakup. It’s mandatory.”

“Please make me look different. Older, maybe.”

I draw her eyebrows first, which are overplucked now and penciled in. Her face is maturing, cheekbones settling into place. I’m not sure if she notices just how different she looks in each portrait, how time unfurls itself across her face more than I can capture.

But with each visit, I started to lose her.

Even in her face and shoulders, I could see she was malnourished and fatigued. Her eyes, gradually sullen, flickered only sometimes at things that used to excite her, like cousins slapping each other in line on particularly hot days, or a goat wriggling loose from the petting zoo. She was shrugging more often, sitting across from me on her phone the entire time, fingers typing almost mechanically – drafting, editing, sending, unsending, always in a hurry. “Hold on,” she’d say, “I’m texting my friends. Yeah, I know, I have friends now.”

June came weekly, then once a month, then once every four or five months, each time her face sinking more and more into an unrecognizable oblivion. I understood the infrequency

– she had friends her own age, now, it'd be weird of me to say I missed her when she was developing new friendships and growing into herself. Despite it, she was less chatty and planetary, her body slumped in the chair, her mind elsewhere. I asked if her new friends were bothering her or if something was happening at home. I said she should bring her new friends, that I'd even do their caricatures at the park after-hours, so it'd all be free. I wondered about her dad's liver. I wondered if her mom had finally left her dad, or if Beezo had died or something.

The more I pressed, the more she pulled away.

Nonetheless, we accepted this phase with humility, and I stopped asking in fear she wouldn't come back. When she visited, we sat in silence, listening to the singing of cicadas and the clatter of wooden coasters ratcheting up their first hill. We nudged dead wasps with our sneakers, their bodies floating in puddles of soda and nacho cheese runoff. She stopped lingering around like she used to, but she'd still sit for a caricature, and we'd talk about customers, her favorite snake species, the beach, sometimes boys or alcoholism, but not too much.

Three months before June disappeared, she brought me candy. It was maybe the hundredth drawing I'd done of her and the hundredth treat she'd brought to share. Those last portraits, she looked so different, not just typical maturation, but as if her bones were being rearranged by God or whoever else while she slept.

"Here," she says, digging in her tote, the same one she always carries. She holds out a fist of individually wrapped caramel candies. "I can't stop eating these and I'm getting fat. Take one." Her eyes ricochet around the booth like pinballs.

"No thanks," I say. Something about her restlessness is new and alarming. "Are you on drugs?"

"No," she says, not offended. She unwraps a candy, her

hands trembling slightly, and begins rolling it around in her mouth. "So, what's happening there?" She gestures at my wrist brace.

I flex my fingers under the fabric. Carpal tunnel. I tell her it's relatively new, how my hand is swollen some days, like today. I wait for a joke about how she's going to hand me over to a retirement home any day now, how she'll have to feed me spoonfuls of canned soup when all my teeth fall out.

She only nods, her gaze retiring on my brace. There's a new pang stretching near my heart when it strikes me I can no longer make out her edges. They're all distant and smudgy because she's older now, her humor evolved.

"What?" I try to joke. "You respect the elderly now?"

"No, I get it. I hate myself for getting it." She pauses. I want to curl up in a ball when she quietly adds, "Don't you see that, Marnie?"

Two years passed. I picked up a second job bagging groceries at Piggly Wiggly and thought about how she'd hate that I let myself go here, in the dead place. She missed the wet-leaf rot of September and the ice-coated brush in the early spring, or the fryer oil incident last May, when a coked-out park guest dipped his pinky into the deep fryer just to see what would happen.

I didn't think about her every day. Just most days.

I realized I was sinking and made plans to leave the state for graduate school or try for an MFA again. One afternoon, when sorting out what remained in my supply bin, I found a scrap of painter's tape with June's mom's name on it. I'd jotted it down out of nosiness, back when June always paid with that credit card.

I typed her name into Google. It's just curiosity, I told myself, that I just wanted to know which hair color she might've moved on to. It was electric pink, box-dyed straight from the drugstore, the very last time I'd seen her.

Her mom's Facebook profile was the third result. Her profile picture was the three of them – her parents bookending her in lawn chairs, June in the middle, her hair the same bright green she'd had the summer we met. She was smiling in a way I remembered, impish and off-center like she'd been caught in the middle of a question or protest. I could hear her voice: *Please just take this crapola already!* At the bottom of the photo, a pale blue profile banner read, "Stop Cyberbullying."

I stared at it, as if it'd eventually explain itself. I assumed it was some campaign, one of those things you do to chime into the internet void, like when Notre-Dame burned down and everyone was posting hoary tourist selfies of themselves in Paris, applying that blue, red, and white French flag filter to their profile pictures.

I closed the tab. I thought that was probably how June's older sister died, from cyberbullying.

It's an unremarkable Wednesday in August, the kind where it's so hot, the air feels broiled, when a petite woman with a familiar face steps into the shade of my booth.

"You're Marnie?" she asks.

I nod.

"I'm June's mom."

I'm still nodding, my head still moving up and down, and while I'm conscious of the nodding, I can't stop it. I try to focus on controlling it instead of whatever else, because I'm scared, so scared, of what she's going to say.

"You might not remember, but she loved coming here. It was a good place for her," she says.

I finally stop nodding but let myself go quiet. She doesn't seem to mind.

She reaches into her purse and pulls out her phone, then hands it to me. "June's bedroom."

I zoom in, pixel by pixel, hoping to disappear into the photo. Frames crowd the walls in dense, symmetrical arrangements. On the bed sits a thirteen-year-old June, wired headphones in, staring at her phone, a small bowl of Bing cherries next to her knees.

"The caricatures," I whisper. They are all my caricatures, every single one. Most are stacked in the corner, still in their plastic sleeves. But about twenty, maybe thirty, line the walls in chronological order—her first portrait to the last. In between is a whole living, breathing thing: the one where she's gripping a turkey leg the size of her head; the summer she drew freckles on her cheeks with eyeliner (and, the following summer, demanded to know why I'd let her do that), her "mall cop era," when she wore mirrored aviators for six months straight. The one when she broke up with Spence, the one when she transferred schools, the one when she finally found a solid group of friends and was obsessed with texting, the ones where she was crying and couldn't tell me why.

"She kept them all," she says.

I can't bring myself to ask. My heart sort of slinks off somewhere, and despite being overcome with the fear of possibility, I ask if she'd like a caricature, since she came all this way. "Sure," she says. "Can you draw my baby, Junie, with me?"

I nod, and for the first time in years, I draw her from memory.

